

Leadtek Winfast PalmTop TV	Pinnacle PCTV USB2	Pinnacle TV to go	Tech-Com SSD-TV-812Plus
36.33	23.37	28.35	23.83
External	External	External	External
×	×	×	×
✓	×	×	×
PAL	PAL	Both	Both
✓	✓	✓	✓
✓	✓	✓	×
×	✓	✓	×
✓	✓	✓	✓
28	41	42	22
Both	Both	Both	Both
Media Player Control, PIP	Media Player Control	Media Player Control	None
USB Data, AV-In	USB Data	USB Data	Audio, USB Data, MMI
None	None	None	None
WinFast PVR, Cyberlink PowerDVD, Orb, Ulead's Cool 3D, DVD MovieFactory 3SE, VideoStudio 9 SE DVD	Pinnacle PCTV TVCenter Analog	Pinnacle PCTV MediaCenter, Pinnacle Studio QuickStart v10	PVR Application
✓	✓	✓	✓
✓	✓	✓	✓
✓	✓	✓	✓
✓	×	✓	✓
✓	✓	✓	✓
✓	×	✓	×
✓	×	×	×
37.25	34.16	36.99	30.16
9	9	9	9
9	8	9	7
85	78	83	75
✓	✓	✓	✓
9	8	9	6
3,900	3,490	5,500	1,595
2.58	2.88	1.83	6.30
76.16	60.41	67.17	60.29



+ Excellent video quality
- A bit expensive



+ Decent video quality
- A bit expensive



+ Good performance
- Expensive



+ Inexpensive
- Below average video quality

out a doubt, the most rugged of them all, with a strong metallic casing. The sleek VideoMate U900 is shaped like and as small as a cigarette lighter. The U890 has the appearance of a USB thumb drive. The Hauppauge TV Tuners are housed in elegant translucent casings.

Windows Media Center Edition and Vista Media Center Readiness

Windows XP Media Center Edition compatibility and Vista readiness exists only on the

Leadtek Winfast Palmtop TV, while the Pinnacle PCTV to go is only XP MCE compatible. We would like to make it clear that when we speak of compatibility and readiness, it does not mean that only those TV-Tuners that are “ready” for these operating systems can be used with them. With the proper drivers and their own PVR, non-compatible TV-Tuners can work without a problem, but they will not function with the inbuilt PVRs of these operating systems.

Performance

Ease Of Installation And Use

Driver installation was hitch-free in all the cases. The PVR software provided by all the TV-Tuners were functionally almost on par; only, the one that comes with the Tech-Com does not have an interface as good as the others.

The Field Tests

In the channel detection test, there was not too much of a variation. The Compro VideoMate Action Pro detected 86 of the 90 channels, while the Leadtek WinFast PalmTop TV was very close, at 85. The Tech-Com did 75, which is not too bad a figure. Fine-tuning of channels was necessary in all the cases.

As far as image quality goes, there were several contenders for top spot. The Compro VideoMate Action Pro, the Hauppauge duo, the Leadtek Winfast, and the Pinnacle PCTV to go are the best. The Tech-Com is at the lower end, its image quality can still be called decent.

External Set Top TV-Tuners

Many people—such as those who leave their homes and stay at rented accommodations in another city—have a computer that is used for study or work. Recording is not of importance to them, and they’re not too technically inclined—and also do not want to get themselves a TV set. For such people, there are External Set Top TV-Tuners, which don’t need a computer: all they need is a monitor. These are TV-Tuners that offer the best video quality amongst TV-Tuners of all kinds.



Compro VideoMate Action Pro
Missed by a Whisker